

MONGOL CLOTHING IN THE YUAN PERIOD^{*}

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The subject of this paper is clothing, specifically the costumes of the Great Mongol Empire. It is based on recent archaeological discoveries from the territory of the Yuan and the Juchid realms, and in particular on my personal study of the textile finds from Nartiin Xad and Buxiin Xušuu, Mongolia. The reconstruction of some of the costumes from there have made it possible to have a more complete picture of the clothes and to recognise their parallels not only among the other archaeological finds, but also as regards the figural representations of the era. The data of these costumes together with the written sources provide us a new way of understanding the clothing culture of the Mongol imperial era.

Key words: archaeological textiles, clothing, costumes, Mongol, Yuan, Ilkhanid, Golden Horde, Chronicon Pictum.

Introduction

Thomas T. Allsen in his monograph has written about the connection of clothes and political cultures of the Mongol Empire and suggested that his historical studies should be continued by “specialists on textiles” (Allsen 2001, p. 10). This paper tries to focus on the costumes of the empire and to define the characteristic features that made them “Mongol” in the eyes of the contemporaries. To make this problem even more complicated, similar costumes, worn by non-Mongol people, appear in the figural representations from outside the Mongol Empire. The meaning of these clothes must have been different there; but even the Great Mongol Empire contained a diverse

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population and the Mongol army itself consisted of different ethnic elements. Emphatically, the term “Mongol” is used in this paper to indicate those peoples of the Great Mongol Empire who, regardless of their ethnic background, were members of the empire’s ruling and/or military elite and can be identified by their gravegoods and in pictorial representations by wearing “typical” Mongol costumes. To define the precise meaning of this expression and the different virtual messages of these clothes inside and outside the empire are the subjects of this paper.

1. Historical Background: the Great Mongol Empire

The Great Mongol Empire was the “largest transcontinental (contiguous) empire of the pre-modern world” (Morgan 2007, p. 5). It was founded by Chinggis Khan in the Mongolian heartland in 1206, and reached its greatest extension under his descendants during the 13th century. Before his death, Chinggis Khan allotted appanages (*ulus*) to the members of his family, and to some of his generals (Jackson 2009, pp. 39–40). By the end of the 13th century the Great Mongol Empire had disintegrated and there were four appanage empires under the Chinggisids’ rule: the Jochid realm (Jochi’s *ulus*) in the northwest, the Chagatai Khanate in the west, the Ilkhanate in the southwest, and the Yuan Empire in the east. Each khanate was ruled by the members of the Qiyat Borjigin clan, i.e. the Chinggisids (the *altan uruy* in Mongolian), who – along with the multiethnic military and administrative elite – constituted the ruling class (Morgan 2007, pp. 99–101). The Yuan Dynasty (大元國 *Dà Yuán guó*) was founded by Qubilai in 1272, after he chose a Chinese name, Yuan (meaning “Origin”) for his dynasty (Rossabi 2011, p. 7; 1994, p. 458). His realm included most of the territory of present-day Mongolia and China. In spite of the political disintegration, the khanates of the Great Mongol Empire, the Yuan Empire in particular, belonged to the most important and powerful political entities in Eurasia until the mid-14th century. Not only their military might but also their crafts and commerce made their influence felt even outside the empire. Their clothing played an especially important role in their political culture and according to Thomas T. Allsen, it was their nomadic cultural heritage that made the Mongol elite to consider textile and clothing as their true display of wealth and power (Allsen 2001, pp. 99–108).

2. Recent Archaeological Discoveries of Yuan Clothes

2.1. The Cave Burials of Mongolia

Until recently, we had only written sources on the visual representations of the clothing of the Yuan Empire. However, in the 20th century, and especially during the last two decades several important archaeological discoveries were made in Inner Mongolia (in China) and Mongolia, from the territory of the former Yuan Empire (Lxagvasüren 2007; Baiarsaikhan 2009; Zhao Feng–Wardwell–Holborn 2004; Oka 2009). The burials at Buxiin Xušuu and Nartiin Xad belong to the numerous cave burials of